Thamesmead
REPORT TO RESIDENTS
April 1997

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Residents are satisfied, survey discovers







THE vast majority of residents are satisfied with the services they receive from Thamesmead. With 77% satisfied, this compares very well with council services. Only 61% of English council tenants are satisfied with their services, according to a National Consumer Council survey.

The Thamesmead survey, carried out by an independent company, found a massive 91% of tenants, and flat and home owners, were happy with their homes.

Nearly three-quarters of the 6,000 households surveyed expected to still be living here in five years time. Three out of five had already lived here for more than five years.

The key problems identified were dog mess and young people hanging about and getting into trouble.

New contracts starting on 1 April this year include a higher cleaning specification and raising of security standards.

Development of more play facilities will soon begin to make an impact.

Urban village plans unveiled

NEW JOBS, shops and leisure facilities will be brought to Thamesmead, with the development of the 'urban village' in West Thamesmead.

The new community will join onto Heronsgate, developing the unused sites along the river. The idea of the urban village is to build houses, shops and businesses at close quarters, with good public transport, to create a lively community and reduce the need for cars.

Gallions Reach will include:

- a riverside walk from Woolwich to Thamesmead town centre
- a new park along the canal that will wind through the urban village
- an enlarged Gallions Lake and wildlife areas
- an artificial hill in a new park that will provide views over the river
- a new centre at Battery Road that may include a petrol station, shops, restaurant or fast food and a budget price hotel.

Final plans for the urban village are currently being considered by Greenwich Borough Council's planning committee.

More than 100 new jobs will be created at new Safeway

SAFEWAY will soon start recruiting for 100 jobs being created in the new foodstore in the town centre. The store will include a bakery, coffee shop, dry cleaners, photoshop and creche, requiring almost double the 170 people who work in the existing store.

The new Safeway will be opening its doors in October and building work has got off to a good start. The site was cleared and levelled during January and February and the foundations are going in this month.

Thamesmere Drive will be closed at the end of March, the buses have a new setting down area outside the swimming pool.

The first signs of the new store are expected this month when the steel frame will be erected.



Preparing the ground: *the new foodstore opens in October*

Older residents offered free smoke alarms

OLDER people living in Manorway and Crossway have received letters, offering them a free smoke alarm. The seven other areas will be mailed within the next two months. All you need to do is fill out and return the tear-off slip and volunteers from the Emmanuel Community Project will come and fit the alarms. Paid for by the company, the alarms have ten year batteries and were supplied at a special price by Dicon.

Taking the hassle out of repairs

GETTING repairs done has never been so easy, thanks to three new services introduced this year.

Repairs Hotline

The hassle has been taken out of reporting repairs – and making appointments – with the new free Hotline. Ring 0800 83 84 81 any time, day or night, seven days a week, and you will get straight through to the repairs or emergency service, free of charge.

Appointments

Appointments can now be made one week in advance for any repair, even if you have already reported it. Just ring 0800 83 84 81. Appointments are made one week advance for all jobs – except emergency call-outs.

Acknowledgement letters

New acknowledgement letters, sent out as soon as you order certain types of repair, will keep you informed about the job. Should you receive one, it will confirm the problem reported, give you the name of the contractor and the maximum time it should take to get the job done.



On call: *Staff take repair requests on the hotline, 24 hours a day*

Repairs service innovations win praise

EARLY results show that the new repairs services have won your approval.

Customer satisfaction questionnaires sent out with acknowledgement letters in January and February showed that a massive 98 per cent of residents were satisfied with the way their repair request was taken and the way the repair was carried out.

A few people felt jobs had taken too long. The housing department is having meetings with the contractors to explore ways of improving the service further.

Brightening up the town

THE new painting and lights for the Coralline Walk garages are just one of more than 40 projects this year, aimed at making the town look better. All improvement schemes have been decided in consultation with residents. Including £300,000 for play, a total of £620,000 will have been spent on environmental improvements this year.



User friendly: *a coat of paint and new lights make the garages feel more welcoming*

Drugs – getting the facts

MORE than 1,600 Thamesmead children have now seen a play alerting them to the dangers of drugs. Theatre Adad staged their show *Wasted* over the past few months in all 16 schools in the area, with sponsorship from Thamesmead.



The children competed to design the best anti-drugs poster. As well as a prize, the winner will see their poster displayed in key sites around Thamesmead.

New intercoms bring sense of security

RESIDENTS of the Moorings can now enjoy the security of their new door entry system. Work has started on a similar scheme for Wren Path in Broadwaters and on all the blocks in Waterfield from Cobden to Kingsley. Some of the old door entry systems in Crossway and Manorway are now being modernised, so that most residents can operate the front door from the safety of their own flat.



Moorings resident Coral McMahon: *the new intercom gives 'great peace of mind'*

A recipe for home improvements

OLDER residents of Shire Court have had new kitchens installed in their homes. Deciding priorities for maintenance and improvement work is always hard. To help with this task Thamesmead has now completed a stock condition survey that provides hard facts about what needs doing when. This will help to guide investment decisions for the next 10 years, though residents' views will be important too.



Mrs Mannis: *work on the new kitchen was done 'very quickly and cleanly'*

Better outlook for Coralline Walk

BRAND new bedroom windows have been installed in 160 homes in Coralline Walk to replace the old metal ones. This will reduce heat loss, improve ventilation and cut out excessive noise. The new pvc windows will be easier to clean and maintain.



Before and after: *new windows at Coralline Walk (right) are better looking and warmer than the old ones (left)*

Expanding opportunities for young children

PROVIDING more facilities for children and young people has long been a priority for residents. Thamesmead has made this its number one concern in recent months. Everyone benefits if young people have interesting things to do, particularly in the evenings and at weekends.

The decision to focus on young people is now bearing fruit with many new schemes and developments being completed. Youth clubs are now opening at the weekends, play facilities have been upgraded in every part of Thamesmead and the youth scholarship scheme expanded.

After a 10 weeks trial, Hawksmoor Youth Centre will be open every Sunday, with continued support from Thamesmead. Building on the success of Hawksmoor Sunday opening, Thamesmead is now sponsoring Saturday opening at Thamesmead Youth Centre.



In the driving seat: *go carts are one of many attractions at Thamesmead Youth Centre*





Balancing act: *playing on the Earthball at Thamesmead Youth Centre is a test of skill and nerve*

Providing more places to play

PLAY facilities for teenagers and children have been upgraded in nearly every part of Thamesmead over the last year, at a cost to Thamesmead of more than £300,000.

In Titmuss Avenue a socialising and sports area for teenagers has just been finished, with a kick-about and fitness equipment. The old tennis courts in Crossway Park have been converted into basketball, football and short tennis courts.

The toddlers play area at Leatherbottle Green is being completely renewed. On Abbey Way a new site will have climbing equipment and slides for three to six year olds and a more adventurous area for the older children.

Basketball nets were installed last month in Warepoint Drive, Broadwaters, Birchmere Park, and Radley House in Wolvercote Road. Five-a-side football nets will also be added for youngsters in Birchmere Park and Radley House kick-about.

Work on the re-development of the play facilities on Tavy Pools is due to start this month.



In the frame: *the new play equipment at Titmuss Avenue*

Come in Number Seven



Landmark: *the new pumping station*

THE finishing touches are just being made to Thamesmead's most unusual building - the new pumping station on Central Way. From this month, it will take over from a temporary plant, pumping sewage, and making possible expansion of the town centre including the new Safeway foodstore.

Despite its practical function, Thamesmead decided to make the new station an eye catcher. The taller cylinder houses the pump room and control centre, while the smaller one has a mess room and space for a transformer. The building is in full view, unlike the other six pumping stations which hide behind brick walls. The station will be operated by Thames Water, which will take over responsibility for maintaining it from Thamesmead, after the first year.

A space to call home

LOOK at the difference it makes building walls and gates to create space outside the front doors. Children can now play safely. Titmuss, Tawney and Booth Closes are the first blocks that will get the treatment this year, with many others planned.

A similar scheme is underway on Hinksey Path. Here some, simple metal work has been included, to decorate the front yards.



Playing safe: *children with one of the new garden walls*

Businesses looking to expand

HALF of all the companies based in Thamesmead are currently looking to expand. That is the optimistic finding of a survey conducted by Thamesmead to discover how it can assist local employers.

Many of the firms are looking for local people to fill the new jobs they expect to be creating.

The survey also uncovered some tips for those looking for jobs. Local papers were the favoured source of recruitment for one in three of the companies, a quarter relied on word of mouth and less than a fifth used job centres and employment agencies.

Thamesmead is doing its bit to help companies expand, buying many goods and services from local firms. A bit of imaginative help can make all the difference.

One local man was looking to set up a painting and decorating business. When Thamesmead offered him help to reproduce a leaflet, enough orders came in for two people to be employed.

Keeping the motor bikes on the roads

STOPPING people riding motor bikes on cyclepaths and walkways is one of the top priorities for Thamesmead residents. The first of a new design of gate was tested last month. This has to stop the motor cycles but not someone with a double buggy, bicycle, wheelchair, motorised disabled vehicle, even someone on crutches.

Already £35,000 has been spent on special fences and less sophisticated barriers – but there is still a lot of work to do.





No entry: *PC Burchell and a local young cyclist lent a hand when the new design of barrier was tested last month*

Tuning in to the Millennium



Millennium managing director Rodney Collins: *a new name for a new station*

A big new sound is booming out over Thamesmead, with the relaunch of the radio station. Out goes RTM, welcome Millennium 106.8 FM.

Managing director Rodney Collins says: 'We decided to look forward not back. The Millennium Exhibition is coming to Greenwich, and as we are the local radio station for Greenwich and Bexley we decided to badge ourselves as Millennium 106.8 FM.'

The new station will have more talk. News, travel, sport and weather information will dominate the peak weekday hours, from 6 am to 7 pm, and Saturday mornings.

But, says Collins, local news will not be squeezed out. 'We have beefed up our own news team and have an unrivalled local news and information service.' Saturday afternoons are devoted to local sports coverage and once a month a programme will look in depth at housing issues, in Thamesmead and nationally.

But don't forget to retune your set. After three years of negotiation about the poor quality of the old RTM signal, the Radio Authority approved a new, and stronger, frequency.

And at 106.8 FM, Millennium has trebled its range. More than 850,000 people can now pick up the station, from Sydenham and Bromley to Thurrock and the City.

More youth scholarships on offer this year

FOLLOWING a successful first year, Thamesmead is expanding its unique youth scholarship scheme.

This year, younger children will be able to apply to the scheme, which offers free memberships of a sport or hobby club for a year.

In the coming year, 150 free subscriptions will be on offer, 50 more than last year, and children as young as five will be able to apply.



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